

Introduction:

Mixed messages

The first time I was told to “be a man” was in fifth grade. I was at a friend’s house playing Xbox after school when he paused the game, looked left and right, and said, “Do you want to see some porn?”

I didn’t know what that was, but from the way he said it, I assumed it was bad.

“No thanks,” I said, trying to focus back on killing aliens.

“Aw, come on! *Don’t you wanna be a man?*” he responded. My face got hot. I squirmed in my seat. I didn’t want to be childish, but I also didn’t like what was happening. Even more than both of those things, I wanted to be liked and respected by my friend. *I am a man!* said fifth-grade me. “Sure.” I’d quickly caved. We walked into the back bedroom where his mom kept the computer.

Two years later, I went to my small group at church. I hadn’t prepared for the Bible study. “Next time, *be a man* and do the homework,” my small group leader said. I hung my head. Other guys in the group had done the work. One other guy didn’t, but he wasn’t exactly an honors student. I didn’t want to be like him, but I was. I felt exposed; I was a part of the wrong group.

That next year at school, the basketball team was joking around before practice

started. One of the guys we'll call Jimmy jumped up and grabbed onto the net hanging from the rim and then pulled himself up so he was able to grab onto the rim. Then another guy did it, then another. Then I tried, but couldn't. I grabbed onto the net, but couldn't pull myself up. I hung there, arms flexed but going nowhere, with the guys in a circle below me looking up at me.

"Be a man, fatty!" Jimmy yelled. I let myself fall, landed on my feet, palms and pits sweaty. Feeling flush and clammy, I silently shuffled my way back into the circle to join the spectators. That night I looked in the mirror and for the first time didn't like what I saw. *Was Jimmy right?* I asked myself. *Yes, I answered myself. Yes, he is.*

None of these guys were speaking about maleness when they told me to be a man. They weren't telling me to go and get XY chromosomes. They weren't asking whether I had all the right parts. They were talking about *masculinity*. They were telling me about what males were supposed to want, do, and be capable of. At least, as far as they understood it.

MASCULINITY IS ...

Masculinity is what a male is *like*. What he does, how he speaks, and how he lives out his maleness.

The fifth-grade me heard that to be masculine was to be sexual, the seventh-grade me to be responsible, and the eighth-grade me to

be strong and fit. Is that what it means to be a man?

My first experiences with the “masculinity” questions were shameful: You’re not sexual enough, not responsible enough, not strong enough. Maybe that’s just inherent to the process of puberty, or maybe it’s just the effect of social pressure.

In my later teenage years, things seemed to get even more complicated.

“What even is a *man*?” A close friend asked me this question, with tears in his eyes, during my freshman year of college. We met up for coffee to talk about our first semester of classes. He told me he’d been “feeling like himself” lately because he’d been taking estrogen pills he bought online. Taking the pills made him feel in control. He thought he might be trans. I didn’t know what to say—I hadn’t heard of that before. The first thing that came to mind was the videos we had to watch in gym and health class about the adverse effects of taking steroids, so I told him it was stupid to take hormones without a doctor’s supervision.

“I don’t *feel* like a man,” he continued, “but when I take these, I feel alive.” Again, I didn’t know what to say.

What did it feel like to be a man? What did it mean to feel alive? What did it mean to feel dead? I only knew what it feels like to be me and, even then, I was barely in touch with my own inner life.

I told him he was dumb and changed the subject. I withdrew from him, feeling spooked and stupid and awkward myself, and never asked him about it again. We grew apart. He wasn't asking me about biology; he was grappling with his psychology. He confided in me and I dropped the ball, unequipped and insecure.

Today, after having being a pastor for more than ten years, the pain of the masculinity question only continues to get more acute.

"Am I *still* a man?" A man asked this, with tears in his eyes. We were at a coffee shop. He was wrestling with permanent erectile dysfunction that resulted from his ongoing battle with cancer, and it was taking a toll on his marriage. His wife felt unloved and unlovely. He felt quite literally emasculated. He wasn't asking me about his chromosomes; he was wrestling with the loss of something he'd taken for granted for so long. I, again, didn't know what to say.

IS MASCULINITY EVEN A REAL THING?

Some say masculinity isn't real, that it's imaginary; just a stereotype or a social construct. Masculinity, it's said, is like Santa Claus, a story we tell children to get them to behave in socially acceptable ways.

When we look for answers to the masculinity question, we find a lot of wild ideas.

When I did an initial Google search looking for an answer to the question, "How to be masculine?" one of the first articles that

came up was about several ways to become a beast. Is being more masculine the same as being more like an animal? To become wild, unpredictable, a predator? After all, my favorite workout supplement company is literally named Animal.

The counterfeits are abundant. Usually, we can sniff them out. Yet, what is the authentic vision we can share for masculinity?

This is why I wrote this book: Being a man isn't complicated. It's difficult; but it's work God has made you able to do.

This book is for men who want to know what it means to be a biblical, masculine man. This book is for dads who want to grow with their sons. This book is for women who want to know if their boyfriend is husband material or not. This book is for moms who want to help disciple their sons. This book is for pastors and youth leaders who want to speak with confidence into the world of counterfeits.

Now, let's "*go on* toward maturity" (Heb. 6:1).